

Module 4: Drivers of Migration

Graduate Research Project

Modeling Multi-Causality: A Systems Analysis of One Migration Flow

Overview

Build a systems model (causal loop diagram or equivalent) of the interacting drivers behind one significant migration flow, and use it to evaluate the dominant public narrative about that flow.

Aligned learning outcomes

- Model complex driver interactions (Grad 1)
- Evaluate dominant narratives against evidence (Grad 2)

Sample research questions

- How do economic, political, environmental, and violence drivers reinforce or dampen each other in your chosen flow?
- Where does the dominant narrative ('they come for jobs' / 'it's all violence') diverge from the evidence?
- Which intervention points does the systems model suggest, and which popular interventions does it predict will fail?

Methods

Case-study method combining published data and scholarship with formal systems mapping (causal loop diagram; optionally a simple stock-and-flow model). Justify every causal link with a cited source.

IRB / research ethics

Not required — published sources only.

Deliverables

- 4,000-word case analysis with the systems model as a central figure
- Annotated model appendix documenting evidence for each link

Grading rubric

Each criterion is scored at one of four levels, then weighted as shown. The overall grade is the weighted combination of criterion scores. Instructors may adapt weights and descriptors to local requirements.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Rigor of the systems model — every link evidenced 35%	Evidence and accuracy are exemplary: rigor of the systems model — every link evidenced is met with high-quality, correctly cited sources for every substantive claim; terms, facts, and frameworks are used precisely.	Evidence and accuracy are solid: rigor of the systems model — every link evidenced is met for nearly all claims, with only minor sourcing gaps or imprecisions that do not affect conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are uneven: rigor of the systems model — every link evidenced is partly met — some claims lack support, sources are thin or misread, or terms are used loosely in ways that weaken conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are deficient: rigor of the systems model — every link evidenced is not met; key claims are unsupported or wrong, and errors undermine the work's conclusions.
Quality of the narrative evaluation 25%	Analysis is genuinely insightful: quality of the narrative evaluation goes beyond summary to produce non-obvious, well-defended conclusions; concepts are applied accurately, complexity is preserved, and counterpoints are engaged seriously.	Analysis is competent: quality of the narrative evaluation is achieved with clear reasoning and accurate use of course concepts, though conclusions stay near the expected.	Analysis is thin: quality of the narrative evaluation is attempted but leans on summary or assertion; concepts are named more than used, and complications are avoided.	Analysis is absent: quality of the narrative evaluation is not achieved; the work describes without analyzing or draws conclusions its own material does not support.
Case knowledge and source quality 25%	Evidence and accuracy are exemplary: case knowledge and source quality is met with high-quality, correctly cited sources for every substantive claim; terms, facts, and frameworks are used precisely.	Evidence and accuracy are solid: case knowledge and source quality is met for nearly all claims, with only minor sourcing gaps or imprecisions that do not affect conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are uneven: case knowledge and source quality is partly met — some claims lack support, sources are thin or misread, or terms are used loosely in ways that weaken conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are deficient: case knowledge and source quality is not met; key claims are unsupported or wrong, and errors undermine the work's conclusions.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Clarity of writing and visuals 15%	Communication is publication-ready: clarity of writing and visuals is achieved with precise, well-organized prose, correct citation, and figures or formats that make the argument easier to grasp.	Communication is clear and professional: clarity of writing and visuals is achieved with minor lapses in polish, organization, or citation that never obscure meaning.	Communication is understandable but rough: clarity of writing and visuals is only partly achieved — disorganization, citation errors, or unclear figures make the reader work to follow the argument.	Communication impedes the work: clarity of writing and visuals is not achieved; errors, disorganization, or missing citations obscure the substance.